

PERSONALISED TRAVEL JOURNAL



From Tea Mountains to Turquoise Lagoons

Our Honeymoon — Sri Lanka & Maldives

17 August — 6 September 2026 · 21 days

Between roots, adventure and paradise

PROLOGUE

Three stories in one journey

After our wedding, we chose a trip that looks like us: adventure, encounters, extraordinary landscapes, and a return to our roots.

Over 21 days, we'll circle the island — Jaffna, the Cultural Triangle, the east coast, the tea-country train, the south coast — before flying to an overwater villa in the Maldives to celebrate my husband's 30th birthday together.

This trip carries three threads:



Our honeymoon — the first big trip as husband and wife.



My husband's 30th birthday, celebrated in a setting like no other in the Maldives.



A return to the land of Jaffna, where my parents lived — Mathagal and Pandatharippu.

This journal was built from everything we've discussed: our wishes, our budget, the places saved on the map, and every adjustment along the way. Times, hotels and prices are working proposals — to be confirmed before final booking.

Our international flights

Confirmed booking · Qatar Airways · 2 passengers · €1,390.36

Paris (CDG) → Colombo (CMB)

Sun 16 Aug, 22:40 → Mon 17 Aug, 16:50 · 1 stop · 14h40 flight time · Economy · QR38, QR654

Colombo (CMB) → Paris (CDG)

Sun 6 Sep, 11:25 → Sun 6 Sep, 21:10 · 1 stop · 13h15 flight time · Economy · QR661, QR37

OVERVIEW

The route

20 nights on the ground (17 August to 5 September), looping around the island with a private driver, without doubling back — except Colombo, the unavoidable hub.

- 1 Colombo**
arrival — 1 night
- 2 Jaffna · Mathagal · Pandatharippu**
family roots — 2 nights
- 3 Cultural Triangle** — Sigiriya, Pidurangala, Dambulla, Polonnaruwa, Minneriya
2 nights
- 4 Trincomalee · Pasikuda**
north-east coast — 2 nights
- 5 Kandy**
1 night
-  **Train Kandy → Ella**
the country's most famous railway
- 6 Ella · Haputale**
mountains, tea, waterfalls — 2 nights
- 7 Yala**
safari, scheduled before its Sept 1 closure — 1 night
- 8 Arugam Bay**
surf, wild beaches — 1 night
-  **Colombo → Malé**
flight to the Maldives
- 9 Maldives**
overwater villa, birthday day — 2 nights
- 10 Ratnapura**
gem mine visit, en route — day trip

11

South Coast — Tangalle (+ Rekawa turtles), Mirissa, Hiriketiya, Unawatuna, Galle
5 nights

12

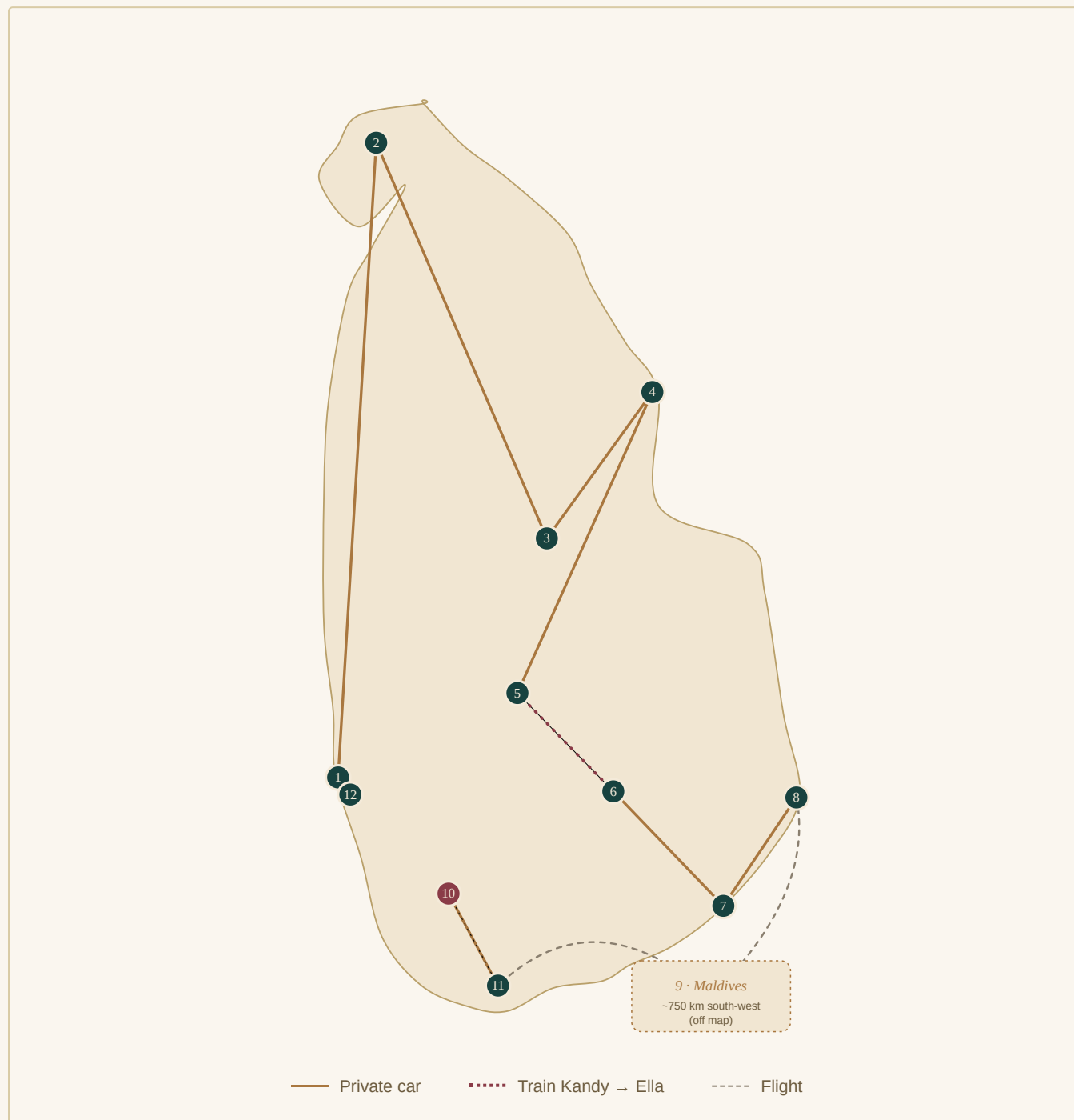
Colombo

final day — 1 night, then flight home

Aunt Easwary and her brother Rasan live in Colombo (two separate homes) — Jaffna is therefore a hotel-based leg dedicated to family roots (Mathagal, Pandatharippu), without assuming they join that leg. Yala is kept and scheduled before its annual 1 September–15 October closure. Ella was trimmed from 3 to 2 nights to make room for it safely.

The route, on the map

Each stage placed at its real relative position on the island, with the mode of transport for each leg.



The island outline is a stylised illustration (not an official cartographic tracing) — the relative position of each stage, however, follows real geography.

PROGRAMME

Day by day

Private driver throughout the land loop — only the Kandy-Ella train and the flights (Jaffna optional, Maldives) escape it.

Day 1 — Arrival		Mon 17 Aug
Colombo		
arrival private car		
FLIGHT	Landing CMB 16:50, driver pick-up, transfer to hotel.	
EVENING	Galle Face Green at sunset, light dinner — jet lag (+4h30 with Paris).	
NIGHT	Colombo, hotel.	

Day 2		Tue 18 Aug
Road to Jaffna		
private car ~6-7h		
DAY	Direct A9 road to Jaffna (alternative: domestic flight ~1h if you'd rather save time).	
EVENING	Check-in at the hotel.	
NIGHT	Jaffna, boutique hotel (1/2).	

Day 3		Wed 19 Aug
Mathagal & Pandatharippu		
roots keepsake		
DAY	Visiting the places where your parents lived — family home, school, places of worship — unhurried, no fixed schedule.	
ALSO	Nallur Kandaswamy Temple, local market, optional Nainativu island or Casuarina Beach.	
OPTIONAL	Delft Island (Neduntheevu) — wild ponies, the only place in the country, Portuguese-era baobabs, almost no tourists. 1h30 drive + 1h ferry from Kurikkaduwan — subject to sea conditions on the day.	
EVENING	Traditional Tamil dinner.	
NIGHT	Jaffna (2/2).	

Day 4

Thu 20 Aug

To the Cultural Triangle

private car

~4h

DAY	Direct road Jaffna → Anuradhapura → Sigiriya/Habarana (without going back through Colombo).
LATE AFTERNOON	Check-in, sunset over the jungle.
SUNSET BONUS	Pidurangala Rock climb (30-40 min, steeper scramble) for a view across to Sigiriya itself — far fewer people than the main site.
NIGHT	Sigiriya/Habarana, jungle lodge (1/2).

Day 5

Fri 21 Aug

Sigiriya, Dambulla, Polonnaruwa & the elephants

early start

safari

photo spot

6:30AM	Climb Sigiriya Rock before the heat and the crowds (~2h round trip).
MORNING	Dambulla cave temples (Buddhist frescoes, statues).
AFTERNOON	Polonnaruwa by bicycle (Gal Vihara, royal city).
LATE AFTERNOON	Minneriya safari — "the Gathering" of wild elephants (peaks July-September).
NIGHT	Sigiriya/Habarana (2/2).

Day 6

Sat 22 Aug

To the east coast

private car

~2h

DAY	Road to Trincomalee, Koneswaram Temple, beach check-in.
NIGHT	Trincomalee (1/2).

Day 7

Sun 23 Aug

Trincomalee & Pasikuda

beach

snorkelling

DAY	Pasikuda beach (calm waters, easy snorkelling), relaxation.
QUIETER OPTION	Marble Beach or Kuchchaveli, north of Trinco, if you'd rather avoid busier Nilaveli.
NIGHT	Trincomalee/Pasikuda (2/2).

Day 8

Mon 24 Aug

Road to Kandy

private car

~3h30-4h

MORNING	Road to Kandy.
BONUS	Udawattekele Forest Reserve, just behind the temple — a quiet forest walk, or the far-less-visited Lankatilaka/Gadaladeniya temples.
AFTERNOON	Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic, Peradeniya Botanical Gardens.
EVENING	Kandyan dance ceremony.
NIGHT	Kandy.

Day 9

Tue 25 Aug



The Kandy → Ella train

unmissable

photo spot

DEPARTURE	Morning train (~8:30-9am) — book 2nd class observation or 1st class in advance, numbered seats.
WHERE TO SIT	Right side facing forward for the best tea-plantation views.
SCENERY	Nuwara Eliya, waterfalls, bridges, an ocean of tea bushes, the Nine Arch Bridge from the carriage.
SNACKS	Vendors walk the train: samosas, wade, hot tea.
DURATION	~6-7h with frequent delays — plan for the whole day.
ARRIVAL	Ella station, driver (car repositioned during the journey) collects the luggage.
NIGHT	Ella/Haputale (1/2).

Day 10

Wed 26 Aug

Ella — sunrise and hiking

hiking

Nine Arch Bridge

6AM	Sunrise at Little Adam's Peak (easy, 45 min).
QUIETER OPTION	Ella Rock instead — a longer hike, far fewer people, an equally stunning view.
MORNING	Nine Arch Bridge on foot, ideally as a train passes.
AFTERNOON	Tea plantation visit and tasting, Diyaluma Falls.
NIGHT	Ella/Haputale (2/2).

Day 11

Thu 27 Aug

Yala — safari

private car

~2-3h

safari

MORNING	Road to Yala via Buttala.
LATE AFTERNOON	Jeep safari — leopards, elephants. Scheduled here deliberately: Yala closes annually from 1 September to 15 October, so this is the last safe window.
NIGHT	Yala.

Day 12

Fri 28 Aug

Arugam Bay

private car

~2-3h

surf

- MORNING** Road to Arugam Bay via Okanda — a remote, near-empty surf point on the edge of Kumana National Park (elephants, peacocks nearby), or Peanut Farm, a locally-run hideaway 20 minutes south of town.
- AFTERNOON** Beach time, Main Point.
- NIGHT** Arugam Bay (1 night only, to connect with the Maldives flight).

Day 13

Sat 29 Aug

✈ Off to the Maldives

romantic

overwater villa

- MORNING** Transfer to Colombo (domestic flight or road), onward flight to Malé (~1h20).
- TRANSFER** Speedboat or seaplane depending on the resort (seaplane for the aerial view — great for photos).
- NIGHT** Maldives (1/2).

Day 14

Sun 30 Aug



The 30th birthday

don't miss it

See the full programme on its dedicated page →

Day 15

Mon 31 Aug

Return via Ratnapura — gem country

private car

💎 gem mine

- MORNING** Flight Malé → Colombo.
- MIDDAY** Inland detour via Ratnapura (~2-2h30 from Colombo) — visit a working gem pit (hand-dug shafts, traditional washing and sorting, nothing industrial) with an expert guide, plus Bopath Ella waterfall on the way.
- AFTERNOON** Road to Tangalle (~2h30-3h from Ratnapura) — a long day, but the only thing scheduled for it.
- NIGHT** Tangalle (1/5 on the south coast).

Tangalle & the Rekawa turtles

private car

 turtles

AFTERNOON

Beach, relaxation.

8-11:30PM

 Turtle Watch at Rekawa (~15 min from Tangalle): 5 marine turtle species come here to nest. Red light only, silence, no flash. Peak season is April-July — late August remains possible, with somewhat fewer guaranteed passages.

NIGHT

Tangalle (2/5).

Mirissa & Hiriketiya

beach

nightlife

MORNING

Mirissa — whale watching in season, beach.

AFTERNOON

Hiriketiya — horseshoe-shaped surf bay, beach club.

NOTE

This leg falls outside the south coast's high season for nightlife (which peaks November-April) — expect a quieter version of the beach-party scene.

NIGHT

Mirissa/Hiriketiya (3/5).

Unawatuna & Galle

history

shopping

MORNING

Galle Fort (ramparts, colonial lanes, shops).

AFTERNOON

Unawatuna and Dalawella Beach, relaxation.

NIGHT

Unawatuna/Galle (4/5).

Bonus day — Rumassala Sanctuary

rest day

secret spot

DAY

Rumassala Sanctuary, a near-empty coastal forest right next to Unawatuna — a quiet nature walk instead of another crowded beach, or simply a free day to slow down.

NIGHT

Unawatuna/Galle (5/5).

Day 20		Sat 5 Sep
Back to Colombo, final moments		
shoppingrooftop		
DAY	Road to Colombo, certified gem shops, Pettah district.	
EVENING	Farewell dinner on a rooftop, city views.	
NIGHT	Colombo, hotel near the airport.	

Day 21 — Departure		Sun 6 Sep
Flight to Paris		
flight		
11:25	Departure Colombo (CMB) → Paris (CDG), arriving 21:10 (via Doha).	

HIGHLIGHT



My husband's 30th birthday

A day designed entirely for him, in the most romantic setting of the trip — the overwater villa in the Maldives.

- 8am** **Floating breakfast** delivered on a tray by the villa's edge, coffee and tropical fruit.
- 10am** **Snorkelling** on the resort's reef — tropical fish, maybe a turtle.
- 1pm** **Light lunch** on the terrace, nap.
- 3pm** **Couple's spa** — a two-person massage with a lagoon view.
- 6pm** **Photo session** at sunset on the jetty.
- 8pm** **Private dinner on the beach**, set table, candles, Sri Lankan/Maldivian menu.
- 10pm** **Surprise** — cake, a personal note, a symbolic 30th birthday gift.

Book ahead directly with the resort: the floating breakfast, couple's spa, and private beach dinner are experiences that fill up fast in high season.



The Rekawa turtles

~15 minutes from Tangalle (Day 16) — one of the country's most important nesting beaches.

Rekawa Turtle Watch

- Five marine turtle species come here to nest: loggerhead, hawksbill, olive ridley, green, and leatherback.
- The visit starts at the Turtle Conservation Project's visitor centre around 8pm, with sightings between 8:30 and 11:30pm.
- Strict rules: red light only, silence, no flash, no touching — a community-run project (Nature Friends of Rekawa) since 2012.
- Best season: April to July (5 to 15 turtles a night), or full-moon nights January to April. Late August remains workable, with fewer guarantees — this is nature-watching, never certain.

Backup if no turtles show that night: the Kosgoda Turtle Hatchery (further west, towards Bentota) lets you see hatchlings raised in captivity before release — less wild, but guaranteed.



Nightlife guide

Your south coast leg (Mirissa/Hiriketiya, 2 Sep) falls outside high season — the nightlife scene there peaks November-April. Arugam Bay, by contrast, is in full swing (east coast, dry season April-September): that's where the atmosphere is most reliable.

Arugam Bay — in full season

Mambo's SATURDAY

The week's big night, right on the sand at Main Point — deep house, bonfires, until sunrise.

Sababa @ Whisky Point FRIDAY

Reggae and techno facing the ocean.

Full Moon Party — Whiskey Point MONTHLY

~\$5 entry, classic surf/beach vibe.

Hiriketiya & Mirissa — off-peak, still active

Secret Jungle Party FRIDAY

Up to 2,000 people in high season, house music, proper sound and lighting — a quieter version in late August/early September.

Dots Bay House SATURDAY

Hostel/bar/co-working space in Hiriketiya, live music + DJ past midnight.

Zephyr & Doctors House MIRISSA, EVERY NIGHT

Barefoot beach bars, DJs, fire dancers, laid-back vibe.

Colombo — reliable all year

Savage Colombo DAYS 1 AND 20

Techno/deep house, international DJs — the country's most professional scene if you want guaranteed clubbing.

SELECTION

Where to stay

Three different worlds depending on the leg: staying with locals, infinity pools deep in the jungle, and cabanas right on the sand.



Staying with locals

Besides the family nights in Colombo (Aunt Easwary, uncle Rasan), the Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority's (SLTDA) official Home Stay programme lets you stay with certified local families — home-cooked breakfast and dinner included, often for the price of a hostel bed.

- Ideal in Ella/Haputale and along the south coast, where family-run guesthouses are plentiful and well-reviewed.
- Reliable platforms: homestay.com, Home Stay Lanka, or directly through the SLTDA registry.
- Book 2-3 weeks ahead for the best choice — these are often small properties (2-4 rooms).



Infinity pools, jungle views

CULTURAL TRIANGLE (SIGIRIYA/HABARANA)

Heritage Kandalama

- Geoffrey Bawa architecture, the building stretching over a kilometre along a cliff face.
- Three infinity pools, one with a direct view of Sigiriya Rock through the canopy.

Alternatives: Sigiriya Jungles Resort & Spa (pool facing the rock) · Taru Villas Maia (jungle-view chalets, pool over paddy fields, only 10 rooms)

ELLA / HAPUTALE

Thotalagala

- A converted planter's house at the heart of a working tea estate.
- 14-metre infinity pool, panoramic views over the Haputale hills, high tea included.

Alternatives: Nine Skies (pool overlooking the Demodara railway loop) · 98 Acres Resort (chalets on a tea estate, view of Ella Rock)



Cabanas, right on the sand

ARUGAM BAY

Stay Golden

- 5 hand-built wooden cabanas, natural materials, set away from the town's bustle.

Alternatives: Jetwing Surf (cabanas + infinity pool + spa) · Aloha Cabanas (a local institution since 1995) · Hilltop Cabanas (25km north, secluded)

TABLE

Restaurants

Sea views, jungle views, natural light — the picks follow the thread of the trip.



Sea view

MIRISSA

Mirissa Eye

- Toes-in-the-sand dining, direct ocean view — book at least an hour ahead, always full.

MIRISSA

MILA Mirissa

- Bright coastal cuisine, tropical brunch in the morning, sunset cocktails in the evening.

HIRIKETIYA

Layback Rooftop

- Rooftop at the Layback surf camp, view over the horseshoe bay.



Jungle view, full of light

SIGIRIYA/HABARANA

Heritage Kandalama — open dining room

- Wide glazed dining room over the canopy, distant view of Sigiriya.

HABARANA

Taru Villas Maia — open-air terrace

- Open-air dinner facing the paddy fields, intimate setting (only 10 rooms).



Notable bar

HIRIKETIYA

Smoke & Bitters

- Named among Asia's 50 Best Bars in 2022 — cocktails built around smoke and bitterness.

The meals at Aunt Easwary's and uncle Rasan's in Colombo remain, without a doubt, among the best of the whole trip.



The finest photo spots

Sigiriya	From the summit at sunrise.
Pidurangala Rock	Looking back at Sigiriya, at sunset the evening before.
Nine Arch Bridge	As the train passes, ideally late morning.
Ella Rock / Little Adam's Peak	Sunrise over the tea hills.
Thotalagala pool, Haputale	Infinity edge over the plantations, morning light.
Overwater villa, Maldives	Aerial view from the seaplane on arrival.
Arugam Bay at sunset	From the main beach, fishermen's silhouettes.
Mathagal	An emotional moment, to capture with family.
Galle Fort	Ramparts at sunset, colonial lanes.

Detailed budget

Target: €6,000 for two, excluding France ↔ Sri Lanka flights (already booked — €1,390.36). Indicative baseline — to refine once hotels are confirmed.

ITEM	TARGET BUDGET
 Sri Lanka accommodation (16 nights, excluding family)	€1,300
 Maldives (2 nights, overwater villa)	€1,300
 Domestic flights Colombo ↔ Malé (+ optional Jaffna)	€500
 Private driver (fuel, tolls, daily rate)	€450
 Restaurants	€700
 Activities (Sigiriya, 2 safaris, train, turtles, gem mine, snorkelling, spa...)	€850
 Shopping / contingency	€250
 Massages / extras / nights out	€300
Estimated total	€5,650

A safety margin of around €350 to stay under the €6,000 target — tighter than before given the driver across the whole loop and two safaris.

What we won't cut

The overwater villa in the Maldives, one infinity-pool jungle night (Thotalagala or Kandalama), the Kandy → Ella train, both safaris, the Rekawa turtle evening, and the romantic 30th-birthday dinner.

Checklist & practical tips

To prepare

- ☐ Sri Lanka ETA visa (online, before departure)
- ☐ Passports valid 6 months after return
- ☐ Maldives resort booking + transfers
- ☐ Kandy → Ella train booking (numbered seats)
- ☐ Private driver confirmed for the whole loop
- ☐ Travel insurance (cancellation, health)
- ☐ Vaccinations / anti-malarial treatment if recommended
- ☐ Copies of bookings in PDF + paper
- ☐ Cash for rural areas / family
- ☐ Light clothing + one dressy outfit (birthday dinner)
- ☐ Sunscreen, insect repellent, first-aid kit
- ☐ Red-light torch (Rekawa, no flash)

Practical info

 SIM / eSIM	Dialog or Mobitel eSIM, activated before departure (Airalo) — good coverage even in Ella and Arugam Bay.
 Money	Sri Lankan rupees (LKR) in cash for small vendors and family; cards accepted at hotels and tourist restaurants.
 Weather (late Aug - early Sep)	East coast (Trinco, Arugam Bay): dry season, ideal. South-west (Mirissa, Galle): monsoon, afternoon showers possible. Maldives: southwest monsoon, brief afternoon rain, otherwise sunny — and 30-50% cheaper resort rates.
 Gemstones	Buy only from certified shops (National Gem and Jewellery Authority) in Colombo or Ratnapura.



21 DAYS FOR A LIFETIME OF MEMORIES

Between jungle, ocean and love

*This journal is a starting point — tell me what feels right,
what needs to change, and we'll refine it together.*